



BEEST

Parent's Guide

19–21 August 2026 · The Hague, Netherlands

ORGANISED BY HACK CLUB · A REGISTERED 501(C)(3) NONPROFIT

Dear Parent or Guardian,

Welcome to beest, and thank you for supporting your teenager's place at the event.

At Hack Club we have a simple philosophy: young people learn best by making real things: not by sitting through lessons, but by building, shipping, and working it out as they go. We believe learning to build "turns you from a consumer into a creator", and that the confidence it gives a young person lasts long after the project is finished. Beest, a Hack Club hackathon, is that philosophy made physical.

We appreciate that this may be your child's first solo adventure, first international trip, or first hackathon, so thank you for placing your trust in us. This guide answers the practical questions honestly: how your child gets there, who is looking after them, what is paid for, how we handle food and allergies, timings, support and more.

Euan

Event Organiser, beest · Hack Club

What's inside

1	About Beest & what Hack Club is	3
2	Dates, flights & getting there	4
3	Location & accommodation	5
4	What's covered & the cost to you	5
5	Food, allergens & dietary needs	6
6	Safeguarding & the adults present	6
7	Code of Conduct, policies & consent	6
8	Health, medical & emergencies	7
9	What to bring & before the event	7
10	Visas, school absence & the team	8

About Beest

What's a strandbeest?

Strandbeest (*Dutch for "beach beast"*) are mechanical walking sculptures invented by Theo Jansen, an artist from the Netherlands who has dedicated his life to making these uniquely engineered goliaths. They've gained international recognition for their nigh-organic movement, developed through years of iteration and study, famously walking across the beaches of the Netherlands powered only by wind. Though these facts alone make witnessing the Strandbeest a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity, the true marvel is their simple construction: Jansen approximates life with only cloth, pipe, and zip ties. Jansen has spent 40 years of his life masterminding their evolution, and this summer the artwork goes on exhibit. We hope your teen can attend this one-of-a-kind experience with us. For reference, here is a video of a past exhibit: youtube.com/watch?v=ANhA94ZqnEQ

So, what's Beest then?

Beest, the Hack Club event, is a free, three-day event in the Netherlands where teenagers will attend the strandbeest exhibit, explore the city and culture of The Hague, and build their own mini strandbeest. To qualify, participants have built impressive technical projects and published them online in an open source format, working hard for 40 hours on their passion projects to earn a ticket.

Why should I trust Hack Club?

Hack Club is the world's largest nonprofit network of teenage builders, funded by donors such as Michael Dell (CEO of Dell Technologies), Dr Lisa Su (CEO of AMD), and the Musk Foundation. Our mission is to inspire teenagers to teach themselves to program, and we regularly run events across the globe to achieve this. Previously we ran Juice (youtube.com/watch?v=Gtjyyu82pw4), where 100 teens flew to China to run a juice café with games they'd made, and Campfire Flagship, where 75 teens flew to LA to build games with the YouTubers they grew up watching. We've been doing this for years, and it's a magical experience every time.



Photos from past Hack Club hackathons.

Dates, flights & getting there

The event runs over three days, from the morning of **Wednesday, August 19th 2026** to the afternoon of **Friday, August 21st 2026**. Staff remain nearby over the following weekend to escort participants to the airport on Saturday and Sunday. We recommend arriving a day early in case of travel disruption; if needed, we will provide free accommodations for affected attendees.

Getting there

The arrival airport is **Amsterdam Schiphol (AMS)**, the main international airport of the Netherlands and our expected point of arrival for all attendees. From there, they will be met by a Hack Club staff member, who will escort them to Schiphol train station (a 10-minute walk). Unless we have arranged otherwise, participants will board the NS Intercity Direct train to Den Haag HS. Another staff member will be waiting for them at this station, which is only a three-minute walk from our venue, The Hague Tech (thehaguetech.com), and a short walk from our accommodation, The Social Hub, within 10 minutes on foot. Outside of allotted times during which participants with a freedom waiver can roam freely, attendees will be escorted from point to point by staff members at all times.

Hack Club uses a platform called Attend (attend.hackclub.com) to check participants in and out, track flights, and manage room assignments and participant needs (including allergens, disability needs and medical conditions). All participants will receive an invite by email, and a parent's signature on a waiver is required to attend. There are two waiver options: a **freedom waiver** trusts your teen to explore The Hague without staff present, while a **non-freedom waiver** means they are always accompanied by staff outside the venue.

During the event

We will have a near-full day allocated to exploring The Hague. As mentioned above, this is supervised at parental request. Unsupervised participants will carry contact cards with staff phone numbers in case of emergency, and there are check-ins and group meet-ups at lunchtime. On Friday, everyone travels to Scheveningen beach for the strandbeest exhibit at Het Puntje (hetpuntje.nl), a beautiful beachside café. The journey is a 10-minute walk, around 20 minutes on the number 9 tram towards Scheveningen Noord, then a 30-minute walk across the beach.

Flights & travel costs

Flights and visa fees are supported through **travel stipends**: participants earn \$8 toward travel for every hour they log beyond the 40 hours required to qualify. These travel grants are redeemable through the Beest platform's shop.

Please don't book travel independently until the team has confirmed your child's place in writing. If you're not flying in, if your child will arrive at a different airport, or if you will arrive particularly early or late, get in touch and we'll arrange pickup as needed. Parents are welcome to accompany their teenager in transit, but are not permitted to attend the event

itself, as every adult present must be background-checked; as a nonprofit supporting teens, we are also unable to provide travel stipends to parents.

Location & accommodation

Beest is based in The Hague, on the Dutch North Sea coast. Build sessions (where your teenager will assemble their own replica Strandbeest) run at **The Hague Tech**, an indoor innovation hub three minutes' walk from Den Haag HS station, and Scheveningen beach, home of the strandbeests, is a short tram ride away.



The Hague Tech, our indoor venue in The Hague. Photos: The Hague Tech.

Where will my teenager sleep?

Accommodation is in a **hostel**, arranged and paid for by Hack Club for the duration of the event. Rooms are gender-separated and shared only with other Hack Club participants: no outside guests, and staff sleep in separate rooms.

What's covered & the cost to you

For teenagers who qualify, beest is **free to attend**. Hack Club is a nonprofit and does not profit from the event.

Hack Club provides

- Hostel accommodation for the event
- All meals and snacks during the event
- Local travel during the event
- All materials, tools & workshop costs
- On-site supervision and staffing
- Event merchandise
- Travel & visa stipends

Families plan for

- Getting to your home airport
- Flights & visa fees (offset by stipends)
- A valid passport
- Personal spending money (optional)
- Travel & medical insurance
- Personal medication, toiletries & clothing
- A foreign SIM card to communicate

Packing list: see "What to bring" on page 7.

Food, allergens & dietary needs

Meals and snacks are provided throughout the event. We regularly run hackathons across the world and are used to accommodating all dietary and allergen needs: we can provide vegetarian, vegan, halal, gluten-free and dairy-free options, plus kosher and most other requirements by request. We only ask that you accurately report these needs when setting up a profile on attend.hackclub.com, so that the whole team is aware. Food will be self-serve, with the 14 EU-recognised major allergens labelled. If no provided food is safe or suitable, the participant will receive a \$20 grant to order food through delivery apps.

Safeguarding & the adults present

The safety of participants is the ultimate priority of Hack Club. All Hack Club staff present are background-checked adults, and the whole team undergoes safeguarding training before the event. We also ensure at least one member of staff present is first-aid trained.

Throughout the event and the following weekend we will have a dedicated hotline, staffed 24/7. Call **+1-855-625-4225** to speak directly to staff at the event.

Our full safeguarding policy can be found at hackclub.com/safeguarding.

Code of Conduct, policies & consent

Every participant and adult agrees to Hack Club's Code of Conduct, published at hackclub.com/conduct. In short: treat everyone with respect; harassment, discrimination and unsafe behaviour are not tolerated.

What happens if someone breaks the Code of Conduct?

We act to protect participants. Depending on what happened, that can mean a warning, removal from an activity, a ban from future Hack Club programs, and, where appropriate, notifying law enforcement.

Health, medical & emergencies

Before the event

- Complete your child's **medical and consent details** on attend.hackclub.com, listing conditions, medication and emergency contacts

During the event

- A first-aid trained adult is on-site
- Parents are contacted promptly about anything beyond minor first aid
- Staff can accompany a participant to medical appointments if needed

What to bring

This list is not comprehensive, but covers the main expectations we have around packing.

- A laptop and charger (with an EU plug adapter)
- A mobile phone and charger
- A power bank
- Clothes, including warm and waterproof layers for the coast and clothes that can get sandy
- Toiletries and any personal medication, clearly labelled
- A reusable water bottle

Before the event: information sessions

As the date approaches, we will run information sessions for parents. Euan will be running one this Friday, 24 July 2026 - the joining details will be shared in our Slack community, and your child will be told as and when more sessions are available.

Visas & travel documents

The Netherlands is part of the Schengen Area, so whether your child needs a visa depends on their nationality. Hack Club supports applicants through visas.hackclub.com, providing an official invitation letter and supporting documents for a Schengen short-stay visa where required. Visa application fees can also be offset by the travel stipends described on page 4. The supporting letter is by no means a guarantee of approval, but is our best way of helping.

School absence support

Beest falls in mid-August, which aligns with school holidays in many countries, but not all. If your child needs authorised time off, we can provide a **formal letter to the school** on Hack Club letterhead, confirming the dates, the educational nature of the event, and the supervision arrangements. Please fill out the form at forms.hackclub.com/beest-school-absence to request this.

The team & contacts

Event organisers	Joaquin, joaquin@hackclub.com Asc, ascpixi@hackclub.com Euan, euan@hackclub.com
Questions channel	#beest-help on Hack Club Slack
On-site emergency line	+1-855-625-4225
Website	beest.hackclub.com

From all of us on the Beest team, we're looking forward to exploring the Netherlands with your amazing teenager. Please feel free to contact us at any time with questions or concerns. Thanks for letting your teen be a part of Beest!